

Cancer warning labels on alcohol urged

Surgeon general calls for highlighting the risk in light of growing scientific evidence.

By Karen Kaplan and Melody Petersen

Alcoholic drinks are a leading cause of cancer and should carry a warning about that risk on their labels, the U.S. surgeon general said Friday.

Alcohol is a factor in nearly 100,000 newly diagnosed cancers each year and roughly 20,000 deaths from the disease, U.S. Surgeon General Vivek Murthy said in an advisory intended to focus the public's attention on the health risk.

By comparison, traffic accidents tied to drinking kill about 13,500 Americans each year.

"Alcohol consumption is the third leading preventable cause of cancer in the United States, after tobacco and obesity," the 22-page advisory said.

"While scientific evidence for this connection has been growing over the past four decades, less than half of Americans recognize it as a risk factor for cancer."

Labels on bottles and cans of alcoholic beverages already warn about drinking while pregnant. They also warn about drinking before driving or operating other machinery.

In California, the voter-approved Proposition 65 also requires businesses that serve or sell alcoholic beverages to provide a warning about health risks, including cancer.

Any decision to update or expand the label would require congressional approval, an uncertain prospect. Murthy was appointed by President Biden, who has a little more than two weeks left in office. President-elect Donald Trump has picked Janette Nesheiwat, an executive at a New York-based chain of urgent care clinics, as his nominee for surgeon general.

Executives in the beer, wine and spirits industry said Friday that the science [See Alcohol, A6]



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

WATER flows in the Los Angeles River, next to the 5 Freeway, on Friday. Southern California is below average levels for precipitation.

Southland rainy season hasn't been

Four months in, most of Southern California is in 'moderate drought' status, with what a weather service meteorologist says is one of the top 10 driest starts recorded

By Grace Toohey

California is entering the fourth month of what is typically the rainy season, but in the Southland, the landscape is beginning to show signs of drought.

The last time Los Angeles recorded rainfall over a tenth of an inch — the threshold that officials typically consider helpful for thirsty plants and the reduction of wildfire risk — was May 5,

when downtown received just 0.13 inches of rain.

"It's safe to say this is [one of] the top 10 driest starts to our rainy season on record," said Ryan Kittell, a National Weather Service meteorologist in Oxnard. "Basically, all the plants are as dry as they normally are in October."

California's wet season can run from October to April, although most of the precipitation occurs from December to Febru-

ary.

Current forecasts show little hope that a needed storm could develop in the next few weeks, and the Southern California landscape — ripe for wildfire and never far from chronic water shortages — is paying the price.

Much of the region, including the majority of Los Angeles, San Bernardino, Riverside, Orange and San Diego counties, has fallen into moderate drought conditions, according to a U.S.

Drought Monitor map released this week. The last time the Southland saw similarly dry conditions was in early 2023, as the state was exiting a punishing, years-long drought thanks to an exceptional kickoff to the wet season.

Prior to the recent drought report, conditions in Southern California were considered to be "abnormally dry" for the last few weeks. Much of the Central Valley [See Drought, A5]

Johnson reelected speaker after votes flip

He survives on first ballot when holdouts switch to support him.

By Lisa Mascaro, Farnoush Amiri and Kevin Freking

WASHINGTON — Republican Mike Johnson won reelection to the House speakership on a first ballot

Friday, pushing past GOP hard-right holdouts and buoyed with support from President-elect Donald Trump.

A collection of hard-line Republicans convened in the back of the House chamber during a tense roll call on the first day of the new Congress, one by one declining to vote or choosing another lawmaker. The standoff sparked fresh turmoil sig-

naling trouble ahead under unified GOP control of Washington.

In the end, however, Johnson was able to flip two remaining holdouts who switched to support him, drawing applause from Republicans.

Johnson, in his first speech, vowed to "reject business as usual" as Republicans take charge.

"We're going to drasti-

cally cut back the size and scope of government," he promised.

Johnson's weak grip on the gavel has threatened not only his own survival but Trump's ambitious agenda of tax cuts and mass deportations as Republicans sweep to power. Even his close alliance and backing from Trump himself, usually a sure bet for Republicans, [See Speaker, A5]



JACQUELYN MARTIN AP

MIKE Johnson had the backing of President-elect Trump in his bid to remain House speaker.

Bird flu renews debate over a tool of promise, risk

Researchers divided on experiments that could track the threat, but also accelerate it.

By Susanne Rust and Karen Kaplan

As the H5N1 bird flu virus steamrolls its way across the globe — killing wild animals, commercial livestock and even some people — scientists and health officials fear we're on the precipice of another global pandemic.

But when, where and how that could come to pass is hard to predict — in part, some researchers say, because of guardrails the federal government has placed around gain-of-function research.

The term describes experiments that seek to understand a virus' potential to adapt to new hosts, spread more easily, survive longer in the environment and cause those infected to [See Bird flu, A6]



U.S. Department of Agriculture

CARETAKERS determine the color of a milk sample at the National Animal Disease Center in Ames, Iowa. Many virologists have steered clear of gain-of-function research, a tool that some say is increasingly needed.

Sentencing date set for Trump

Judge rejects request to overturn conviction in hush money case. President-elect won't face jail. **NATION, A4**

Cause probed in O.C. plane crash

Experimental aircraft hit a furniture store in Fullerton shortly after takeoff, leaving 2 dead, 19 hurt. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Always eager to spring ahead

For Chiles and Malabuyo, college gymnastics is about helping UCLA win — and having fun. **SPORTS, B12**

Weather

Decreasing clouds. L.A. Basin: 63/48. **B8**

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